Today, the Arab states of Egypt and Jordan have partnered with Israel in fragile peace agreements. But the increasingly militant Palestinian "refusal front," under changing monikers, is the present justification for a decades-long struggle against an enemy that may change names but is pursuing the same aim: pushing the "Zionist entity" out of the Arab Middle East.

These are military confrontations, but in this instance, war is not only the belligerents' politics by other means, but much more: it is religious passion and world politics by other means.

Among Jews, the religious motivation has been present in the yearning for a return to Zion since the High Middle Ages. It found its expression in prayers, of course, but also in an abundant literature from that time on. Theodor Herzl, the author of *The Jewish State* and founder of political Zionism, was not attuned to it, but a significant segment of East European Jewry, who joined the Zionist movement, were aware of these religious roots and in part motivated by them. The religious dimension of Zionism did not play a crucial role until the Six-Day War and the Israeli conquest of the biblical territories and the whole of Jerusalem. Afterward, it surged as a messianic movement, with Zionists convinced that these conquests were the beginning of redemption.

On the Arab side, the religious presence is more directly linked to political and military action against Israel. Hamas was established in Gaza in 1987 by the imam Ahmed Yassin, its full name being the Islamic Resistance Movement. In many ways, Hamas descended from the Muslim Brotherhood, and in Gaza it became the herald of refusal politics, of the rejection of any political arrangement with Israel. Its stance led to a direct confrontation with Yasser Arafat's Fatah, which agreed, after the Oslo Accords of 1993 and 1995, to recognize Israel and work toward a two-state solution of the conflict. In 2006, Hamas won the elections to the Palestinian Legislative Council. In 2007, Hamas evicted Fatah and took control of the Gaza Strip.